# THE NEW EQUATION

**AFTER THE GALWAN FREEZE, MODI AND XI MOVE TOWARD A RESET OF THE TERMS OF ENGAGEMENT, BUT CONTENTIOUS BORDER AND TRADE DISPUTES COULD CURB PROGRESS**

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**MOVING FORWARD** PM Modi and Chinese president Xi Jinping at BRICS Summit, Sept. 12

**WHEN PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI WELCOMED CHINESE PRESIDENT XI JINPING WITH A FIRM HANDSHAKE** at Bharat Mandapam in Delhi on September 12, his greeting carried more weight than just diplomatic courtesy. On the sidelines of the 18th BRICS Summit, the two leaders were testing whether India and China could build what officials on both sides have cautiously started calling 'a new equation'. It was Xi's first visit to India in nearly seven years. Also, the first since the deadliest India-China border confrontation in over four decades erupted on the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in 2020, dealing a severe blow to bilateral ties.

The process of military disengagement and political reopening had in fact begun in October 2024, days before another Modi-Xi meeting at the BRICS summit in Kazan, Russia. That normalisation broadened further when the two leaders met on the sidelines of the SCO (Shanghai Cooperation Organisation) summit in Tianjin, China, in August 2025 and declared that India and China were "development partners and not rivals". Their recent Delhi bilateral meet, then, is to be viewed as a significant effort to define the terms of how the thaw can endure through more ambitious border arrangements, deeper economic engagement and restoring connectivity.

The Delhi detente was the result of quiet, deliberate statecraft in Beijing a fortnight before the BRICS summit, led by National Security Advisor Ajit